is scant or undocumented, though it cannot be ruled out given the sheer scale of the trade.

According to historian Scott Levi, Hindu merchants enjoyed considerable state protection in Islamic central Asia, a factor integral to the growth of their commercial network.[26] A 17th century farman, or official ruling, in Bukhara, now in Uzbekistan, stated as much:[27]

> We are thinking about the condition of the greater community of people . . . The goods and property of these people should not become ruined; they are protected. Their protection will come from here and their hopes should be directed to Bukhara. Regarding the Hindus who live in the territories of Bukhara, Balkh, Badakhshan, Qunduz, Taliqan, Aibek, Ghuri, Baghlan, Shabarghan, Termiz, Samarqand, Nasaf (Qarshi), Kish, Shahrisabz, and wherever else they may live: who knows the *aqsaqal* (community elder) must obey and respect him as he is working in their best interest.

Khatri merchants lived in caravanserais during their long sojourns that lasted several years and lived separately in quarters marked for Hindu merchants.[28] They could celebrate Diwali and Holi and follow other religious practices inside these quarters with rites being performed by Brahmin migrants who circulated with the mercantile diaspora. They could also participate in other celebrations by consuming alcohol and narcotics which were prohibited for the local population. This caused some friction, but more than liquid it was smoke that caused resentment among the locals who simply could not fathom the Hindu cremation ceremony.[29] The ashes would then come back to India on the return journey, perhaps giving a new interpretation to the Hindu belief in ‘transmigration’ of the human soul.

Khatri merchant migration was male-dominated and semi-permanent in nature.[30] The principal directors of the trade were based in greater Punjab and entrusted their wares and capital to agents who would return after several years, if not decades. Returning agents would have to produce their *bahi*s, or books of accounts, to their directors to square trading positions, repay debts, or deposit a part of the profits. In the interim, information would flow across towns through travelling merchants and *hundi*s, sophisticated financial instruments that limited the use of physical currency.